

Go beyond elections

Democracy doesn't only happen on Election Day. Elections matter, but many government decisions are made between elections. Use AI to find out when your participation could actually make a difference.

Step 1: Pick a single issue for your group to focus on - 5 min

Choose something you care about. Examples: housing, education, immigration, climate, transportation, AI, healthcare, policing, taxes.

Step 2: Understand the opportunity - 20 min

Ask the AI:

"I care about [*your issue*]. Don't just tell me who to vote for or contact. Help me find the next real decision points on this issue. Identify upcoming hearings, votes, rulemakings, budget decisions, agency meetings, public-comment periods, court proceedings, or implementation deadlines. Tell me when public participation is possible, who actually has decision-making power, and when my participation is most likely to matter. Verify all dates and opportunities with official sources."

Step 3: Deep dive - 15 min

Ask the AI:

"Give me three realistic actions I could take before that decision point. For each, tell me who it targets, what I would do, and what outcome it could realistically influence. Help me write the message to X. Focus on topics A, B, C. Find the contact info so I can send it and give me the best timing to send my message."

Step 4: Discuss together as a group - 20 min

1. Do these actions seem realistic for an ordinary person to take, and what would make you more or less likely to actually do it?
2. Did this exercise change your idea of when democracy actually happens?
3. Which decision point seemed to offer the most meaningful opportunity for public input—and what made it different from simply contacting an elected official?
4. What are the key take-aways? Was using the AI useful?